FILLING THE PROTEIN GAP

INDIA'S COMMITMENT TO REDUCING IMPORTS AND BOOSTING DOMESTIC CULTIVATION OF PULSES SEEKS TO ADDRESS NUTRITION DEFICIENCIES



RAJWANT RAWAT

Free India was born with a food crisis. However, since the Green Revolution in the mid-1960s, the agriculture sector has seen significant transformations. The focus then was grains, putting food on the plate for the hungry millions but in the past decade or so the government's focus has shifted to the protein needs of the people; significantly, boosting the production of pulses. The government's proactive measures to bolster cultivation of pulses and decrease import reliance have yielded remarkable results. Between 2017 and 2023, India managed to reduce pulses imports by an impressive 60 per cent, owing to a 9 per cent surge in domestic production. Buoyed by these accomplishments, the Centre has formulated an ambitious plan for self-sufficiency in pulses production within the next three years. This endeavour hinges on elevating the yields of key pulses such as pigeon pea (tur), black gram (urad) and red lentil (masur). Over the past seven years, India's pulses yield per hectare has surged by 41 per cent, soaring from 655 kg to 924 kg.

India's journey in the production of pulses has been transformative. The pulses output, which stood at 18.24 million tonnes (MT) during 2010-11, reached a record high of 26.96 MT during 2021-22—a surge of 48 per cent. The expansion is not confined to volumes alone; both the cultivated area and yield ratios have also witnessed exponential growth on account of systematic interventions. In 2015-16, pulses were cultivated across 24.9 million ha. (Mha), yielding an average of 656 kg/ha. In contrast, in 2021-22 cultivation was spread across 30.4 Mha, yielding an average of 888 kg/ha.

459
GMs
is the recommended protein requirement per day while rural India consumes only 194 grams per day, according to IFPRI

27
PER CENT
of the global yield of pulses is consumed by India while it produces only a quarter of it

WHY IT IS A GAME CHANGER

Despite these advancements, a stark reality persists. Pulses play a critical role in the Indian diet, serving as a vital source of protein for a segment of the population. Data from the National Family Health Survey-5, published last year, revealed that only 16.6 per cent of men and 29.4 per cent of women have never consumed non-vegetarian food, underlining the existence of segments with a strong vegetarian culture, and thus an absolute reliance on pulses—according to the International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI), rural India consumes only 194 grams of protein a day, against the recommended 459 gms. This brings about an asymmetry: while India accounts for a quarter of global pulse production, it consumes nearly 27 per cent of the global yield. In real volumes, that two per cent difference looms large as an onus on policymakers. What they have to attend to is this dual role of India, as both a major producer and consumer of pulses.

The implications are far-reaching. NITI Aayog projects a demand of 32.64 MT by 2029-30, necessitating tech-